



IFDC RESOURCE • NO. 3

IFDC ETHICS GUIDE

MEDIA ETHICS AND THE PROTECTION OF CHILDREN'S RIGHTS

A practical code of conduct for Sri Lankan journalists and editors

A PUBLICATION OF THE INTERNATIONAL FOUNDATION FOR DIGITAL CHILD
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MEDIA ETHICS AND THE PROTECTION OF CHILDREN'S RIGHTS

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Ethical coverage of children is not just about avoiding legal risk — it is about the kind of newsroom culture that treats children's dignity as non-negotiable, in every beat from crime to elections to entertainment. This resource sets out core ethical commitments for Sri Lankan media, organised around the situations where children most often appear in the news.

Make Responsible Reporting a Habit, Not an Exception

- Anchor day-to-day editorial decisions about children in a written code of conduct, not individual judgment calls made under deadline pressure.
- Build in regular internal review of coverage involving children, in the same way outlets already track corrections or complaints.

SRI LANKA IN PRACTICE

The Editors' Guild of Sri Lanka's Code of Professional Practice, enforced through the Press Complaints Commission of Sri Lanka's Dispute Resolution Council, already gives outlets a formal channel: since 2003 the PCCSL has resolved more than 1,500 public complaints against the press through conciliation, mediation and arbitration — a model newsrooms can lean on rather than treat coverage of children as a purely internal judgment call.

Avoid Reducing Children to a Stereotype

- Resist framing children only as victims, as burdens, as troublemakers, or as symbols of a wider social problem.
- Show individuality — a child affected by flooding, poverty or displacement is a person with a name, interests and a future, not an illustration of a statistic.
- Take particular care with children from minority or marginalised communities: one child's image or story should not be used to represent an entire community, whether that is an estate-sector Tamil community, a Muslim community, or an Indigenous Vedda community.

Report on Children With Disabilities Respectfully

- Use accurate, person-first language rather than outdated or medicalised labels.
- Frame stories around ability and agency, not only around limitation.
- Preserve the same dignity afforded to any other child in coverage.

Report on Poverty Without Reducing Children to Victims

- Provide context — why a family is in poverty, what support exists, what is being done — rather than an image alone.
- Avoid imagery that dehumanises: extreme close-ups of visible hardship, or framing designed purely to provoke pity.

- Tell individual, specific stories rather than defaulting to a generic “poor child” narrative.

Keep Children Out of Political Contests

Children should never be used as props in an election campaign — whether to burnish a candidate's image or to attack an opponent. Sri Lanka's own election law and the PCCSL's Code both discourage using minors for political point-scoring; newsrooms should apply the same standard to their own coverage of campaign events involving children.

Protect Privacy and Secure Real Consent

- Treat a child's right to privacy as the default, not an afterthought.
- Obtain informed consent from both the child (in age-appropriate terms) and their parent or guardian before including them in a story.
- Shield children from exposure that could embarrass, endanger or stigmatise them, even where a parent has agreed to participate.

Shield Children From Harmful Content

- Take care with graphic violence, sexual content, or disturbing imagery that a child audience could encounter.
- Use content warnings ahead of distressing news segments, particularly during hours when children are likely to be watching.

Educate the Public, Not Just Report the News

Media outlets can do more than cover incidents involving children — they can help parents, teachers and the wider public understand children's rights and how media choices affect a child's development and privacy. A short explainer alongside a difficult story, or a follow-up piece on the support services available, often does more good than the original story alone.

Let Children Speak — Carefully

- Create real opportunities for children to share their own views in coverage that affects them: school policy, transport, climate, digital safety.
- Balance this against ethical and legal safeguards — participation should never come at the cost of a child's safety or dignity.

Support Access to Media, Including Digital Platforms

Sri Lankan children increasingly encounter news through social media rather than television or print. Outlets have a role in making sure the content children do access — whether news, entertainment or educational — is age-appropriate and contributes positively to their development, not just optimised for engagement.

Take Extra Care When Interviewing Children

- Confirm informed consent from the child and their guardian before the interview begins.
- Prepare the child for what the process involves, in language suited to their age.
- Prioritise the child's comfort throughout — a distressed child does not owe a journalist a usable quote.

THE BIGGER PICTURE

Ethical reporting on children is not a constraint on good journalism — it is what allows Sri Lankan media to keep the public's trust while covering the stories that matter most to the country's next generation.

This guide draws on and paraphrases principles set out by Save the Children in partnership with the University of Prishtina “Hasan Prishtina,” Journalism Department, in “Media Ethics and the Protection of Children's Rights in the Media: Guidelines and Code of Conduct,” adapted here with Sri Lankan context by the International Foundation for Digital Child (IFDC). We are grateful to Save the Children for its work advancing responsible journalism and child rights protection. © IFDC — www.ifdchild.org.

GET HELP · REPORT A CONCERN · KNOW YOUR RESOURCES

Sri Lankan Bodies Every Journalist Covering Children Should Know

EDITORS' GUILD OF SRI LANKA

No. 96, Kirula Road, Colombo 05, Sri Lanka

Self-regulatory body for editors — Code of Professional Practice

PRESS COMPLAINTS COMMISSION OF SRI LANKA (PCCSL)

96 Bernard Soysa Mawatha (Kirula Road), Colombo 00500

Web: www.pccsl.lk

Independent Dispute Resolution Council for complaints against the press

HUMAN RIGHTS COMMISSION OF SRI LANKA (HRCSL)

No. 14, R. A. De Mel Mawatha, Colombo 04

Tel: 011 250 5580 / 011 250 5581 / 011 250 5582 · Hotline: 1996

Web: www.hrcsl.lk

LEGAL AID COMMISSION OF SRI LANKA

No. 129, Hulftsdorp Street, Colombo 12

Tel: +94 11 243 3618 / +94 11 533 5329 / +94 11 533 5281

Email: legalaids@sltnet.lk · Web: www.legalaids.gov.lk

Free legal advice and court representation for eligible persons, including in child-related matters

NATIONAL CHILD PROTECTION AUTHORITY (NCPA)

No. 330, Thalawathugoda Road, Madiwela, Sri Lanka

Childline: 1929 (toll-free, 24 hours, trilingual) · Tel: +94 11 277 8911–14

Email: ncpa@childprotection.gov.lk · Web: www.childprotection.gov.lk

INTERNATIONAL FOUNDATION FOR DIGITAL CHILD (IFDC)

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